# The Emptying — Phase 3 System Design (Colony Sim)

Oct 24, 2026 · @William

Detailed design for the colony sim, new systems first. Carried-over systems are reviewed afterward against the earlier Phase 3 doc. Numbers are starting values for balancing.

## Relic influence and obedience

The relic's power is shown as five named tiers that set the ring's size and add to how readily people obey; each person scores every law, and enforcement turns grudging acceptance into compliance at a cost in loyalty. Status: in progress.

### Influence tiers

The player sees tier names, never a number.

| Tier | Ring size | Obedience bonus |
|---|---|---|
| Faint | Small | +0 |
| Present | Medium | +10 |
| Strong | Large | +20 |
| Dominant | Very large | +30 |
| Absolute | Maximum | +40 |

- **Growth:** many sources, defined as data so more can be added. Examples: a slow rise over time, relic enhancer buildings, relics researched, fragments, sacrifices, and followers of the cosmic faith. Growth also feeds the being's escalation.
- **Loss:** losing a fragment, a relic destroyed or stolen, or the cosmic faith purged all reduce influence.
- Population affects influence: more people under the relic means more influence, but each new person adds less than the last, and a huge population is harder to keep obedient.

### Acceptance

Each person scores each law they know about:

**acceptance** = belief on that topic (-100 to +100) + influence bonus + (opinion of the ruler ÷ 4) + 10 for government employees + personality (Rebellious -15, Obedient +15)

| Acceptance | Behavior |
|---|---|
| 0 or higher | Follows the law |
| -30 to -1 | Grumbles; follows it only if enforced |
| Below -30 | Defies it, even if enforced, risking punishment |

- These numbers shift with what happens to each person.
- Colony members living outside the ring still count and still follow your laws, but they're more prone to question them: -15 acceptance on every law.

### Enforcement

- Each law has an enforcement level: None, Light or Strict.
- Strict turns grumblers into followers but adds fear: -2 opinion of the ruler per week for everyone who dislikes the law.
- Enforcement tools are a flexible, data-driven list, so new ones (such as bribes) can be added.

### Unrest and visibility

- A colony-wide unrest meter is fed by defiance, harsh enforcement and unmet bloc demands. High unrest brings protests, then strikes, then riots.
- The laws screen shows, per law, the share who follow, grumble or defy, as accurate as your advisor.

## Beliefs and campaigns

Every person holds a view from -100 to +100 on a set of topics; laws check those views, and campaigns move them slowly, with a risk of backfiring. Status: in progress.

## Topics

- Defined as data so more can be added. Examples: slavery, cults, vampires and other races, executions, the crown, each faith, war, wealth, outsiders.
- Each law ties to one or more topics. Banning cults checks the cults belief.

## Where beliefs come from

- Race, faith, traits, upbringing (children take on their parents' beliefs) and experience.
- Experience can move beliefs sharply. A vampire who saves the village raises views of vampires; one who feeds on a child drops them hard.

## Campaigns

- A campaign moves one topic by 1 to 3 points per day for everyone in range, scaled by the speaker's Social skill.
- People with strong views (±70 or more) move at half speed.
- Pushing too hard (more than 50 points against someone's view) gives a 20% chance per week of backfiring with that person, hardening their opposition.
- **Speakers:** a lord, a priest or a town crier at a government building, each reaching a district-sized radius. More speakers reach more of the kingdom. Priests are twice as effective on faith topics.
- **Cost:** 20 to 50 gold per day depending on scale; running several campaigns at once costs more.

## Soul sap

- A relic power, learned or gained, that saps a person's soul. They become 100% obedient but stop all progression: no ambition, no growth. They do their job, nothing more or less, and still pay taxes.
- Only weak-minded people can be sapped.
- Nobody can see it happen.
- A sapped person abandons their family, which causes its own problems.
- Useful for reliable labor, but sapping everyone soft-locks the kingdom, because sapped people never expand or build.
- Still to decide: its influence cost, and whether it can ever be reversed.

### Other tools

Like a real government, the crown has more ways to shift beliefs:

| Tool | Effect |
|---|---|
| Festivals | A short burst of opinion and a small shift on one topic; costs food and gold |
| Holidays | Recurring days that reinforce chosen beliefs |
| Public executions and punishments | Shift beliefs on crime and the crown; frighten some, harden others |
| Monuments | A slow, permanent push on one topic for everyone nearby |
| Schools | Children absorb the crown's view on chosen topics as they grow up |

## The ruler and succession

The king or queen is a full colonist the relic rules through: they never refuse a law, but they can be worn out, killed or replaced, and the relic picks or engineers what comes next. Status: in progress.

### The ruler

- A full colonist with needs, traits, relationships and a home in the keep.
- Traits change how laws land: a beloved, charismatic ruler gives +10 acceptance across the board; a cruel one makes harsh laws feel natural but kind laws ring hollow.
- **Stress:** passing laws that clash with the ruler's personality adds stress. High stress brings mental breaks like any colonist's: erratic decrees, public outbursts, paranoia.
- The ruler can marry and have children. The royal family is a target for assassins and a source of drama, such as a scheming sibling or a resentful heir.

### Death

- Causes: old age, illness, assassination (by cults, rival kingdoms or angry blocs), riots or a stress breakdown.

- A ruler's death brings a few days of instability: -10 opinion and higher unrest until the successor settles in.
- People take a morale hit when a ruler is killed, unless they hated them.

### Succession

- Two options: the relic chooses, or you set up voting.
- **Choosing:** pick 1 of 3 candidates drawn from lords, the ruler's family and popular figures, each shown with traits, beliefs and how people feel about them. An unpopular pick costs influence and causes unrest; a beloved one makes the transition smooth.
- **Voting:** every adult under the relic votes for 1 of 3 candidates based on beliefs, opinion of each candidate and bloc. Elections happen only at succession. The relic can tilt the vote and back one candidate over another; rigging that people notice costs opinion.
- **Why vote:** it's a power play. You still get everything you want, but the people feel they chose: +10% productivity for the elected ruler's first year.
- **Replacing a ruler:** the relic can arrange an unseen "accident" at a high influence cost. Done often, people grow suspicious and opinion of the crown falls.

### Choosing lords and government staff

- Colonists with high ambition and skill put themselves forward to become lords. When a slot is open, you choose, or leave it alone. People passed over too long grow resentful and may join a cult or a rival.
- **Government jobs:** you open a position and applicants arrive over 1 to 3 days, shown with skills, traits and morality. Honesty and some traits stay hidden unless your advisor or a background check reveals them. You can hire, keep waiting, or delegate hiring to a lord with criteria.

## The ring and fragments

The relic's ring grows with its tier and marks where you rule; fragments start smaller rings of their own, capped by your tier, and the cheapest way to make one is the darkest.
Status: first pass complete.

## The ring

| Influence tier | Ring radius |
|---|---|
| Faint | A small village |
| Present | A town |
| Strong | A town plus nearby farms and mines |
| Dominant | A whole region |
| Absolute | Several regions |

- Exact distances are set once the map's scale is known in the engine.
- The edge shows as a faint shimmer, toggleable as an overlay. Its color shifts with how evil you are, measured by a hidden kingdom morality score: the running total of the crown's acts, slowly fading back toward neutral, so a kingdom can redeem itself or fall. The world reflects it too, with washed-out colors and thinning grass.
- People feel more uneasy the closer they live to the edge, and safer near the center.

## Fragments

- Each fragment creates its own ring, which grows at its own rate but never becomes as large as the main one.
- **Found** at random sites (ruins, cult shrines, creature dens), usually guarded or cursed.
- **Made** by feeding the relic influence, rare materials, and one of: a sacrifice, a researched relic or a long ritual. The sacrifice route is the fastest and cheapest, a constant pull toward the dark path.
- **Traded** rarely, from off-map kingdoms or on-map groups, at a high price.
- **Limit** by tier: 1 at Present, 2 at Strong, 3 at Dominant, 4 at Absolute.
- **Losing one:** fragments can be stolen by cults or raiders or destroyed in a disaster. The settlement around it falls outside your rule: -15 on every law and drifting toward independence or a nearby cult until you recover or replace it.

# Town growth

The town grows naturally: people notice what's missing, groups form around shared needs, and the crown approves, rewards and caps rather than placing. Status: first pass complete.

## How needs arise

- The town tracks shortages (no wood coming in, food running out, nobody selling clothes), and the people best suited to fix each one consider acting.
- **Group projects:** when a large enough group shares a need (followers of a faith you've allowed want a church), they submit a request. You approve or deny. If approved, they choose a spot, form an actual group, split the cost among themselves, and once it's paid for they buy the materials and pay the builders. A group needs at least 8 members, who pay according to their wealth; if it isn't fully funded within 20 days, it's abandoned and the money returned. The crown can top it up or pay the full cost, which pleases the group.

## What people build

- **Without asking:** houses, storage, garden sheds and farms, and possibly more as the design grows.
- Other buildings go through requests, approvals and the business rules.
- Placement follows access (a woodcutter near trees, a mill near farms), personal and race preferences, and closeness to friends and distance from people they dislike, so neighborhoods form naturally.

## The crown's levers

- **Crown requests:** post a need ("a hospital in the east district") with a reward. Higher rewards draw more takers, faster.
- **Grants and tax breaks** for building types you want, weighed by people deciding what to build.

## Discovering buildings

- Like laws, you don't see a building type until someone builds the first one.
- Each type starts capped at 1. You raise caps as the town grows, either because people complain about shortages or because you notice.

### Starting out

- The crown starts with enough gold to build the first 10 to 15 buildings and pay wages for about 30 days, and pays for everything at first.
- **Land and buildings:** like real life, the crown can sell land and buildings (cheaply to the people already working there) and then collect taxes on them, or lease land for a set time. This is how the first settlers become landowners, and how the treasury refills after the expensive start.
- **Running out of gold** doesn't end the game instantly, but it can make the end come quickly: unpaid wages hit mood and opinion, government buildings close, unrest climbs and people leave. If the treasury stays empty for 15 days with no income, the kingdom falls.

### Seeing it

- A "town needs" panel shows current shortages and who's considering fixing them.

## World generation and on-map groups

The world seed generates the terrain and places hand-made points of interest; placing the keep then rolls everything else from region-weighted tables, and small groups grow alongside you (terrain changed to random on October 26). Status: in progress.

### What gets rolled

| Rolled | Range |
|---|---|
| On-map groups | 4 to 8 (cults, bandits, hermits, creature dens, traders' camps) |
| Points of interest | Ruins, shrines, resource sites, relic sites |
| Off-map kingdoms | 3 to 5, each with a leaning, faith and temperament |
| Wildlife | By region |
| Starting people | 3, with random traits, skills and beliefs |

- Each region has weighted tables: a magic forest rolls more creature dens and Cursed immigrants, mountains more ore and hermits, ruins more relics and vampire covens.
- Choosing a keep site shows a popup with information about that location.

- Groups never spawn within a good distance of the keep, and the most dangerous roll farthest away.

### Groups

- Each starts with 1 to 3 people and a goal (a cult wants converts, bandits want loot, hermits want to be left alone).
- They grow as you grow, scaled to your population, capped at about 20 people.
- **By standing:** hated groups raid you; neutral ones ignore you; liked ones trade, send immigrants and sometimes help defend.
- Standing moves through trade, gifts, shared enemies, your laws (banning a cult's faith angers it) and how your people treat theirs.
- **Ending a group:** military force, events, or covert means such as trading them plague-laced blankets.
- As escalation rises, cults grow faster and new ones spawn, some seeded by the being itself. Late-game cults are the main way escalation shows on the map.

## Defense and combat AI

With no direct control, you set alarm levels, muster flags and policies, and soldiers fight according to them and their personalities. Status: first pass complete.

### Alarm levels

| Level | Effect |
|---|---|
| Watch | Guards and soldiers to their posts; civilians keep working |
| Alarm | All fighters to muster flags; civilians to shelters |
| All hands | Every able adult fights |

Higher levels stop more work, so over-alarming hurts the economy.

### Muster flags and squads

- Up to 5 flags, each with a priority and an optional assigned squad or general. Fighters go to the nearest high-priority flag and defend a radius around it.

- Soldiers form squads of up to 10 under a sergeant (a promoted soldier); generals command several squads. Squads that train together build cohesion, a small bonus.

## Policies

Set per squad or general:

| Policy | Options |
|---|---|
| Engagement | Hold position, Defend area, Pursue |
| Target priority | Nearest, Strongest, Ranged first, Weakest |
| Fall back at | Never, 50% health, 25% health |
| Patrol | None, or a route you draw |

## Personality in combat

- Brave soldiers push forward and take risks; cowardly ones hang back (better defense, less damage); bloodthirsty ones chase fleeing enemies against orders; disciplined ones follow policy most closely.
- A good general raises everyone's discipline.

## Warning

- Scouts, watchtowers and liked groups give 1 to 12 in-game hours of warning depending on coverage. With no coverage, raids arrive with no time to raise the alarm.

## After a fight

- The survival math, trauma and grief from the earlier design carry over.
- The first death unlocks a graveyard zone. Bodies are carried there, and a grave digger, a government job you need to staff, has to bury them. Unburied bodies decay and cause disease and bad mood.

# The being's escalation and the director

A hidden stir value climbs as you feed the relic, moving the world through four stages; one director runs every event, and the top stage is survivable but brutal. Status: first pass complete.

## Stir

- A hidden value fed by relics researched, influence tier, fragments held, sacrifices and soul saps, each weighted as data.
- It falls slowly if you stop feeding it: destroying a relic, purging the cosmic faith or ending sacrifices. A cautious player can hover at Stirring forever; a greedy one rides toward Waking for the power.

## Stages

| Stage | Reached at | What happens |
|---|---|---|
| Quiet | Start | Rare odd events, uneasy animals near the relic |
| Stirring | First relics, Present tier | Nightmares, small cults forming, strange immigrants |
| Restless | Several relics, Strong tier | Cult uprisings, possessions, creatures drawn to the relic |
| Waking | Deep relic research, Dominant tier and up | Major events that can threaten the kingdom itself |

**Waking events** include: a possessed ruler issuing decrees on their own, a mass soul sap of the weak-minded overnight, a rift that spawns creatures, and a whole district losing its grass and color while its people sicken.

## The director

- One director picks every event using difficulty settings, colony wealth, population, the stage and recent history.
- It never stacks two major disasters back to back and gives a breather after a big one.
- Event chains are weighted higher at higher stages.
- Waking has no forced ending. Holding on there is the hardest way to play.

## Discovered laws and rules

The law book starts nearly empty and fills as situations arise; your first decision on each becomes both the law and a precedent people remember. Status: first pass complete.

- **Starting laws:** work hours, immigration (open or closed) and basic taxes.
- **Discovery:** the first time a situation arises (a theft, a murder, a cult forming, a vampire immigrant, a slave for sale), the game pauses and presents a decision. Your choice becomes the starting setting for that law, which then appears in the law book where you can change it.
- **Precedent:** people remember the first decision. Executing the first thief sets a harsh tone and shifts beliefs about crime and the crown. Later changes follow the normal flip-flop rules.
- **Delegation:** a lord who owns that area (the warden for crime, a priest for faith) can make the first decision by their temperament if you've set them to. It shows in the report afterward.
- **Rules work the same way:** the first business application asks about license fees and caps, and those become rules.
- **Hints:** the advisor warns of laws you'll probably face soon ("a cult is forming in the north; expect questions about worship").

## Environment, races, disasters and inheritance

Light, weather, race strengths and weaknesses, fire and region disasters shape daily life; paths form where people walk; property passes to heirs. Status: first pass complete.

### Light and darkness

- Every spot has a light level from sun, fire and lamps.
- Darkness raises crime (+50% chance at night in unlit areas), lowers work speed for most races and helps the Cursed. Street lamps are a crown building with a real purpose.

### Race strengths and weaknesses

Each race has 1 to 2 of each, defined as data. Humans have none of either, which makes them balanced.

| Race | Weakness | Strength |
|---|---|---|
| Vampires | Sunlight burns (damage outdoors by day) | Night vision, strong at night |
| Werewolves | Silver, the full moon | Strength, fast healing |
| Demons | Holy ground, cold | Heat resistance, fear aura |

## Weather

- Rain, storms, fog, heat waves, cold snaps and snow by season.
- Weather affects mood, work (no building in storms), crops and darkness (fog and storms count as darker), and can damage buildings.

## Fire and disasters

- Fires start from forges, lightning, arson and accidents, and spread to nearby wooden buildings: faster in heat and wind, slower in rain. Stone resists fire.
- Firefighting is a work permission; wells and fire brigades (a crown building) help.
- Other disasters: plague (spread by bodies, rats and crowding), floods near rivers, crop blight, earthquakes in the mountains and droughts. Each region favors certain disasters.

## Paths and roads

- Foot traffic wears dirt paths into the ground where people actually walk. Dirt paths fade if traffic moves elsewhere.
- A crown road crew automatically paves any path above a traffic threshold. You can mark paths to pave first or never to pave, and order roads destroyed.
- Paving goes from gravel (cheap) to stone (from research), each faster and longer-lasting. People wade slowly through rivers; paving a well-used river crossing builds a bridge.

| Surface | Walking speed |
|---|---|
| Untouched ground | Normal |
| Dirt path | +15% (normal when muddy after rain) |

| Surface | Walking speed |
|---|---|
| Paved road | +35% |

### Inheritance

- When someone dies, their home, business and gold pass to their spouse, then their children.
- With no heir, property reverts to the crown, which can sell it.
- Inheritance tax is a law discovered the first time it comes up.

## Carried-over systems: changes

The earlier Phase 3 doc still applies except where listed here. Status: first pass complete.

| System | Change |
|---|---|
| Colonist simulation | Unchanged, plus light and weather as mood inputs. Sapped people skip ambition and growth |
| Jobs | Building slots (worker, manager, trainer) stay. Permission boxes replace forced assignment; priorities 1 to 4 per work type stay alongside. Permissions let you keep unskilled people off jobs they could botch |
| Lords | No hero: slots start at 0 and grow with population and research. XP comes from defense fights, off-map missions and jobs. Governor becomes the job for running a fragment settlement |
| Laws | The earlier category table becomes the pool of laws waiting to be discovered, with acceptance, enforcement and flip-flop rules applying |
| Economy | Unchanged, except gold no longer goes to claiming keeps; its main uses are campaigns, fragments, crown buildings, wages and trade |

| System | Change |
|---|---|
| Research and map | Some regions and points of interest are sealed by relic shields: find the relic that opens them, or find and destroy the relic powering them. Rivers are waded until traffic and paving produce bridges. Some areas can't be chosen as a starting site. The Diplomatic tab is gone; the Race tab opens through liked groups and creature study |
| Off-map missions | Dispatch missions stay, run from the war room, with the same success math, travel risks and threat ratings. Hands-on small missions are dropped |
| Away report | Replaced by a chronicle: a running, filterable log of the kingdom's events, with the advisor flagging what needs attention |
| Story | Acts, the midpoint sacrifice, the final war and foreshadowing are dropped. Relics with research trees and demands stay |
| The keep | No more rooms. Their functions (war room, treasury and so on) become separate government buildings. The keep itself can be upgraded: a visual change outside, with buffs |
| Religion | Unchanged, except temples are built through group projects by a faith's followers, with your approval |
| Captives | Sources are now raids, defense fights, off-map missions and the slave trade. Everything else is unchanged |
| Combat | Formations become a squad policy. The old off-map battles section is dropped except the survival math, which also resolves off-map missions |
| Equipment | Master buildings become government buildings that train soldiers and hold loadouts. Soldiers still pick the best armor available |

| System | Change |
| --- | --- |
| UI | Hero screens removed. New screens for influence and the ring, beliefs and campaigns, town needs, the chronicle and succession |
| Camera and controls | No unit commands. Tools are permission boxes, zones, flags, menus and approvals |
| Time scale | About 12 real minutes per in-game day by default, adjustable by the player. Rush-pace numbers dropped |
| Trade | Caravans come from off-map kingdoms and liked on-map groups, carrying hard-to-make goods including slaves |
| Threats | Threat formula (wealth plus techs researched) stays, with escalation added on top |
| Saves, game data, audio | Unchanged |